

Kumar was responsible for taking care of the funding and achieving the targets set by various governments in Asia in terms of healing the ozone layer and lowering the amount of chloro-fluoro carbons in the air. The work was quite exciting, as per Kumar, as it gave him a chance to be close to the environment and save it from collapsing.

“One thing I realised while working with the UN is that you are as good as your national counterpart is. If the national counterpart does not work, you cannot work either. It is also my personal opinion that organisations such as the UN are overstaffed. This leads to a lot of duplicity in the work,” explains Kumar.

He adds, “For example UN, UNDP, UNICEF, and the World Bank are all doing the same thing, but it is the money of the people that is funding these organisations.”

He started finding that he had not enough work to do at the UN. He, however, worked for one-and-a-half years more with the UN to make sure that his work justified everything he was getting from the organisation. This was also the time when he had an open offer from the World Bank to leave the UN and start working with them. But he refused!

This is where Kumar actually revealed the brains behind what all EESL does today. Kumar and his then boss sat together to propose forming the EESL. Both of them spoke to Anil Rajdhan and chartered out a business plan around EESL. Kumar was the one who had written the plan for setting up EESL.

“The plan then was written by PwC in a formal way. Initially, when the company was formed around 2010, the ministry wanted me to join as CEO. I politely declined the offer because everybody knew that I was one of the brains behind the forming of EESL. I never wanted people to say that EESL was created by Saurabh because he wanted to be a CEO,” explains Kumar.

This is when Kumar backed away from working with the organisation he had chartered out on paper, the one that would bring him closer to saving energy and environment, and also give business opportunities to a lot of people in the country.



Saurabh Kumar in kitchen

Love at IRS and two daughters

Kumar is married to Anupama Anand, whom he met while being trained for IRS at an academy in Nagpur. His wife is currently posted as Commissioner of Income Tax in the Delhi region. Kumar says his wife is his biggest support. On being asked how he proposed his wife for the marriage and how love struck, he answers in the words of Shakespeare and says, “Love looks not with the eyes but with the mind and therefore is winged Cupid painted blind.”

Anupama Anand has humanities educational background and so must have read a lot of work of Shakespeare. Their elder daughter graduated from the USA and is now working in a digital marketing start-up in Pune. The younger daughter has completed her graduation and is looking for an internship in Boston, USA.

On being asked if any of the two daughters want to be civil servants like their parents, Kumar answers, “Absolutely not, they are not even remotely connected to being or wanting to be civil servants. I and Anupama have encouraged them to choose their own path, and that is what we

want them to do and would be happy to see them do.”

When free, Kumar loves to cook Handi Mutton using an earthen pot over fire originating from cow dung. His colleagues at EESL consider the Handi Mutton cooked by him an absolute delight. And the person who was once an introvert has now transformed into what they call the soul of a party. He never misses a chance to crack jokes and make everybody around him laugh.

All this would have not been possible without the support Kumar gets from his wife. “I have been working continuously for the last eight years, and my wife and daughters have stood by me in every decision I have taken,” says Kumar. Though the couple worked in the same department initially, they have no difference of opinion about anything related to work. Because of the simple reason that they never talk about work once they are back home.

Kumar, in his tenure with the IRS, has also been an assessing officer for all the political parties in India including BJP and Congress. But that’s a story for a different time. **EFY**